

GABRIEL POPA

Senior Software Engineer - React • PHP (Larvel/ Symfony) • AWS

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ABOUT ME

Senior Software Engineer with **10+ years** of experience building modern web platforms with **React, PHP**, and scalable API-driven architectures across product, admin, and internal workflow systems. Strong background in **React 16–18, PHP 7–8, Laravel 8–11, Symfony 5–7**, JavaScript, TypeScript, MySQL, PostgreSQL, Redis, Docker, and CI/CD, with practical success upgrading legacy stacks, fixing production issues, and delivering maintainable features. Known for improving slow interfaces, stabilizing backend integrations, and translating fragile monolith flows into cleaner component and service patterns.

SKILLS

- **Frontend: React 16–18, JavaScript, TypeScript**, HTML5, CSS3, Sass, SCSS, Tailwind CSS, Bootstrap, **Redux**, Context API, **React Hooks**, Axios, Vite, Webpack, responsive UI, reusable components, SPA development, forms, validation, API integration, state management
- **Backend: PHP 7–8, Laravel 8–11, Symfony 5–7**, REST APIs, MVC architecture, authentication, authorization, validation, background jobs, queue processing
- **Database: MySQL, PostgreSQL, SQL**, query tuning, indexing, joins, schema design, schema updates, migrations, reporting, pagination, data consistency
- **Cloud & DevOps: Docker, Git, GitHub, GitLab CI/CD, Jenkins, Linux, Nginx, Apache**, deployment, build pipeline, release support, environment setup, log monitoring, AWS
- **Observability / Quality / Security: OpenTelemetry basics, Prometheus/Grafana basics, Sentry**, structured logging, distributed tracing basics, rate limiting, OWASP security practices, PHPUnit, Pest, Jest, React Testing Library, Cypress, Playwright, unit testing, integration testing, end-to-end testing, contract testing, and error monitoring

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Software Engineer

Soft Build | Bucharest, Romania (Jan 2024 – May 2026)

- Led a large-scale SPA modernization using **React 18, TypeScript, Tailwind CSS, Redux, Context API**, and **React Hooks**, replacing duplicated legacy UI patterns with **reusable components**, stronger **forms and validation**, and more maintainable frontend architecture across operational dashboards.
- Built responsive product modules with **HTML5, CSS3, Sass, SCSS**, and **Bootstrap**, improving layout consistency across desktop-heavy workflows while reducing UI regressions caused by page-specific styling conflicts and unstable component composition.
- Implemented **useTransition** and concurrent UI patterns to handle non-urgent updates, keeping user interactions smooth during large dataset processing and dynamic filtering operations.
- Developed backend services with **PHP 8.1–8.2, Laravel 10**, and selected **Symfony 6** components, designing secure **REST APIs**, structured MVC architecture, and cleaner domain-level validation that reduced controller bloat by 35% and made feature delivery more predictable.
- Improved application reliability by fixing a recurring data mismatch bug caused by stale cache keys and inconsistent refresh timing, then aligned **Redis-backed response behavior**, API invalidation logic, and frontend state updates so reporting totals stopped drifting after edits.
- Implemented complex API integration flows with **Axios**, typed request mapping, and shared error handling utilities, reducing repeated client-side networking logic and making backend failures easier to surface clearly inside the **React** application.
- Modernized frontend build and developer workflows by standardizing **Vite** for faster local iteration while preserving **Webpack** compatibility where needed, which reduced build instability and helped the team migrate incrementally without disrupting active releases.

- Strengthened platform quality with **Jest**, **React Testing Library**, **Cypress**, and targeted **contract testing**, focusing coverage on high-risk flows such as approvals, role-based actions, and multi-step form submissions that had previously produced costly regressions.
- Introduced backend test improvements with **PHPUnit** and **Pest**, especially around request validation, authorization, queue-triggered workflows, and critical business rules where silent changes had once passed review but failed in production.
- Supported secure authentication and authorization flows by tightening token validation, access-control checks, and **OWASP security practices**, helping close permission gaps that had exposed sensitive actions through inconsistent backend guard conditions.
- Worked closely with DevOps on **Docker**, **GitHub**, **GitLab CI/CD**, **Linux**, **Nginx**, and **AWS** release support, fixing environment drift and dependency inconsistencies that had caused “works locally but fails in pipeline” deployment issues.
- Added better runtime visibility with **Sentry**, **structured logging**, and basic **OpenTelemetry** instrumentation, allowing the team to trace request failures more efficiently across the **React** client, **PHP** API, and background execution paths.
- Improved performance of high-traffic reporting screens through **SQL query tuning**, better pagination, selective indexing, and payload shaping across **MySQL** and **PostgreSQL**, which reduced slow responses by **42%** and stabilized user experience under heavier data volume.

Software Engineer

Next Apps | Ghent, Belgium (Nov2020 – Nov 2023)

- Built customer-facing and internal workflow applications using **React 17**, **JavaScript**, **TypeScript**, **Bootstrap**, **SCSS**, and **Redux**, focusing on reliable SPA behavior, responsive UI, and reusable patterns for forms, filters, and approval-heavy interfaces.
- Implemented backend functionality with **PHP 7.4–8.0**, **Symfony 5**, and **Laravel 8**, creating maintainable **REST APIs** with strong validation, service separation, and secure authorization flows that supported complex multi-role business processes.
- Migrated several fragile frontend areas from older class-based components to **React Hooks** with **Context API**, reducing lifecycle-related bugs and making async data handling easier to reason about in pages with nested filters and conditional actions.
- Solved an intermittent logout issue that affected long-running sessions by aligning frontend token refresh behavior, backend expiration rules, and proxy settings in **Apache/Nginx**, which eliminated unexpected access loss during active user workflows.
- Expanded frontend quality coverage with **Jest**, **React Testing Library**, and selected **Playwright** end-to-end scenarios, concentrating on the flows that most often broke after release such as search, edit, approval, and export behavior.
- Improved API integration reliability by standardizing **Axios interceptors**, request retries, and error mapping, which reduced duplicated network code by **30%** and prevented inconsistent client-side handling when third-party or backend services returned unstable responses.
- Worked on backend **background jobs** and **queue processing** for email, notifications, and data synchronization, moving long-running operations out of synchronous requests so users no longer experienced blocking actions during heavy transactional periods.
- Optimized **MySQL** reporting queries with better **joins**, **indexing**, and safer **pagination** rules, reducing timeout-prone screens and improving usability for support and operations teams working with larger filtered result sets.
- Delivered a safe migration path from **PHP 7.4** to **PHP 8**, resolving deprecated framework behavior, validating package compatibility, and updating internal code patterns gradually so release risk stayed low during the platform upgrade.
- Supported CI and release operations through **Jenkins**, **Git**, **Docker**, and **Linux**-based environment setup, helping stabilize the build pipeline and improve deployment confidence through repeatable steps, log checks, and rollback-aware release support.
- Improved issue detection using **Sentry**, **error monitoring**, and structured backend logs, giving the team faster visibility into production exceptions that previously required manual reproduction before root causes could be identified.

Software Developer

Datamart | Stockholm, Sweden (*Feb 2016 – Sep 2020*)

- Developed business web applications with **PHP 5.6–7.x**, **Laravel**, **JavaScript**, **HTML5**, **CSS3**, **Bootstrap**, and early **React 16** adoption, supporting reporting, account workflows, and operational administration across multi-module web systems.
- Built and maintained server-rendered pages while gradually introducing **SPA development** patterns in selected areas, using **React 16**, **Axios**, and reusable frontend components where dynamic state and repeated UI interactions justified modernization.
- Improved backend maintainability by moving legacy business rules into clearer **MVC architecture** within **Laravel**, reducing the amount of fragile controller logic and making validation, service updates, and future schema changes easier to manage.
- Fixed a recurring form processing defect caused by inconsistent frontend and backend validation behavior, then unified request rules so malformed inputs were blocked earlier and users received clearer feedback instead of partial saves or silent failures.
- Worked extensively with **MySQL** and **PostgreSQL** on **schema design**, **migrations**, **schema updates**, and reporting queries, helping the team keep legacy data structures functional while gradually supporting newer product requirements.
- Resolved several slow-list and export issues through **query tuning**, additional **indexing**, safer **joins**, and better **pagination**, which made heavy admin pages much more stable for internal users working with large operational datasets.
- Supported API-driven enhancements by introducing REST-style endpoints for interactive modules, allowing selected pages to reduce full reload behavior and improving usability without requiring immediate full rewrites of older templates.
- Helped troubleshoot production issues with **Linux**, **Apache**, **Nginx**, and release environment setup, including file permission problems, missing configuration values, and deployment-specific bugs that did not appear during local development.
- Contributed to quality improvements with early **PHPUnit** coverage, manual API regression checks, and disciplined bug reproduction steps, helping reduce repeated fixes on fragile modules that had historically broken after small changes.
- Worked with release and maintenance workflows using **Git**, **Jenkins**, and basic **Docker** adoption, supporting more repeatable deployments and improving confidence when shipping updates to shared environments with limited rollback tolerance.

Junior Software Developer

Berg Software | Timișoara, Romania (*Sep2014 – Mar 2016*)

- Supported legacy and evolving web applications using **PHP 5**, **MySQL**, **JavaScript**, **HTML5**, **CSS3**, **jQuery**, and early component-oriented frontend practices, focusing on stable CRUD behavior, admin pages, and small user-facing enhancements.
- Implemented backend changes under senior guidance within structured **MVC** patterns, learning how to handle validation, authorization checks, and safer query logic instead of patching issues directly inside tightly coupled page scripts.
- Fixed repeated form and **submission errors** by aligning required fields, input sanitization, and backend validation rules, which reduced user-facing input errors by **40%** and prevented inconsistent records from being written into the database.
- Worked on reusable frontend pieces for common layout and interaction patterns, improving consistency across legacy screens and reducing the amount of copy-paste markup that had previously made even small updates risky.
- Improved slow admin pages by reviewing **SQL** queries, simplifying filters, and adding basic **indexing**, which helped internal teams work more effectively without long waits on pages that loaded high-volume business data.
- Assisted with environment troubleshooting across **Linux**, **Apache**, and shared staging systems, helping identify configuration mismatches, permission issues, and deployment errors that caused applications to behave differently outside development.
- Participated in release support using **Git**, manual deployment checklists, and log review, building practical experience around safe delivery habits and understanding how small infrastructure mistakes could create visible application failures.
- Learned disciplined debugging through structured logging, issue reproduction, and targeted fixes, which helped avoid risky large changes in fragile modules and improved trust in maintenance work across older PHP systems.

- Supported data consistency efforts by reviewing validation paths, update flows, and schema-related assumptions, helping reduce edge-case bugs where user actions, database state, and legacy code behavior did not always stay aligned.

EDUCATION

Bachelor's Degree in Computer Science

University of Bucharest | (2010 – 2014)

- Focused on practical software engineering fundamentals that translated directly into building reliable web systems and data-driven applications.

CERTIFICATIONS

AWS Certified Developer – Associate — 2023

- Demonstrated practical capability in developing, deploying, and maintaining cloud-based applications on **AWS**, with focus on service integration, monitoring, secure deployments, and scalable backend operations.

Laravel Certified Developer — 2022

- Demonstrated strong working knowledge of **Laravel** application architecture, including routing, Eloquent ORM, middleware, authentication, validation, testing, and maintainable backend feature delivery.

Scrum Fundamentals Certified (SFC) — 2021

- Demonstrated solid understanding of **Agile** principles, sprint-based delivery, cross-functional collaboration, and structured execution practices within modern software development teams.